record of 398/5 Sri Lanka had set against lowly Kenya in 1996. We walked off the field in complete embarrassed silence. It was a terrible feeling to be the first team to concede 400 runs, on our own turf, and it wasn't as if we were a Mickey Mouse side like Kenya either. We were among the top cricket teams in the world. It was downright humiliating.

The upside was that I was beginning to feel like my old self again.

At the turnover in the changing room there was complete silence for 10 or 15 minutes. We were all shell-shocked. This was obviously unknown territory for us, and we had no idea what bladdy targets to set along the way, or how we were going to get to 434. Coach Mickey Arthur gave a very short speech, pointing out that the wicket was perfect for batting and that the boundaries were fairly short. If the Aussies could do it, there was every chance we could too … *if* we remained positive.

'Listen,' said Mickey, 'just try to get to 200-odd in 19 overs and we'll take it from there.' Not the most sophisticated game plan ever conceived, but no one had ever thought Australia would get 400+ against us either.

While Mickey was talking, he looked straight at me, which made me wonder whether he'd heard about my exploits of the night before. I held his gaze and smiled as if to say, 'Well, Mick, if that's the going rate, someone has to give it a go. Might as well be me.' But I didn't really think we would end up chasing down the total, to be honest, especially after Boeta Dippenaar got out for one in the second over.

So there I am, walking out to the middle at number three. Memories of my big night had not receded quite as far back as I would've liked … and the Aussies started to chirp me. As I mentioned earlier in the book, the Aussie management had also been in the Sandton Sun Hotel bar, bearing witness to a good part of my drinking spell. Obviously they'd spread the word that I had been as pissed as a fart the night before. I could hear Michael Hussey saying, 'Come on, boy. Are you still happy? You don't look so happy.' The remarks were flying: 'Somebody give Hersch another glass of wine. Come on, Hersch, just one more.' And all that sort of shit.

Sledging never really bothers me, so I wasn't really taking too much notice. And, as my innings progressed, they quickly shut up. To this day I cannot explain it, but suddenly I was seeing the ball as if it were a football. I couldn't miss a shot – 21 fours and seven sixes later, I had swatted 175 runs to put South Africa in sight of the Aussie total. If I look back at the footage of the match I can see my eyes look deep-set in my skull – always a